Yom Kipper 5785

לכבוד יום כיפור. R' Levi Yitzchok of Berditchev quotes the famous Gemara (בבא בתרא י' ע"ב & פסחים נ' ע"א) which we know is referring to olam hazeh vis-a-vis olam haba: עוֹלָם הָפוּךְ רָאִיתִי - The world is upside down. R' Levi Yitzchok had an ingenious take on this, and it's actually an indictment which we'll have to answer and we will.

He says, in the olden days, בפריערדיגע דורות, אמאל'דיגע צייטן as they say in Yiddish, a person used to deal honestly in his business. He would do his business honestly, he did everything properly, and he never let out a lie from his mouth. That was in the old days. He would go into shul and he would start saying וידוי אשמנו בגדנו גזלנו :יום כיפור on, and there was not any drop of truth to it because they did not doאשמנו בגדנו, they were honest people. So it turns out that in the בית הכנסת he was lying and outside he was telling the truth. He says, today is פונקט פארקערט. People cheat and lie and rob and steal as much as they possibly can, to get away with making as much money as they can. And then what do they do? They go to shul and they say אשמנו בגדנו גזלנו. So he says it's an עולם הפוך.

Now, how do we combat that? First of all, we have to do תשובה. And we have to try to be honest in everything that we do, both business-wise and with everyone around us, and try as hard as we can, particularly in these days of יום כיפור and עשרת ימי תשובה, to try to do whatever we can to be as straight and as truthful as we can be. It's a tremendous challenge. We're so used to absolute out-and-out שקר all around the world. We know that אמת is a very rare commodity, it's hard to find. The letters א' מ' ת' are the furthest apart, whereas the letters ש' ק' ר' are next to each other. It's our moral obligation, our אחריות, to try to do something better, to try to make ourselves better in everything that we do.

Now, in that light, there's a Gemara (ראש השנה ל"ב ע"ב) that's brought down by R' Yechezkel Levenstein, the mashgiach ruchani of the Mir: אָמַר רַבִּי אֲבָהוּ: מַלְאֲכֵי הַשָּׁרֵת לְפָנֵי הַקָּדוֹשׁ בָּרוּךְ הוּא - The מלאכים said to Hashem: רִבּוֹנוֹ שֶׁל עוֹלָם! מִפְּנֵי מָה אֵין יִשְׂרָאֵל אוֹמְרִים שִׁירָה לְפָנֶיךָ בְּרֹאשׁ הַשָּׁנָה וּבְיוֹם הַכִּפּוּרִים? Interesting question. We wouldn't have thought of that, but the מלאכים did. These are days of קדושה and on days of קדושה, it's our job to say שירה before Hashem. Hashem answered them and said the answer which we all know: אֶפְשָׁר מֶלֶךְ יוֹשֵׁב עַל כִּסֵּא דִין, וְסִפְרֵי חַיִּים וְסִפְרֵי מֵתִים פְּתוּחִין לְפָנָיו - The book of life and the book of death are open in front of the king who's about to make a judgment; וְיִשְׂרָאֵל אוֹמְרִים שִׁירָה? In that Gemara, there's a famous שאלה: We know and we count upon, we look forward to Hashem's חסד. We have tremendous אמונה, not because we deserve it, but because we're davening for it, and we hope to have it. And maybe we <u>should</u> work on our אמונה as well. Anyway, whatever the reason is, we have בטחון in הקדוש ברוך הוא, who will find us זכאי במשפט. We made it since last year after all. We're still here, those of us who are here. איי איי נעבעך. איי איי. Those of us who are here. We should learn a lesson from those who are not here. איי איי איי. But those of us who are here, so we see that we have אמונה that הקדוש ברוך הוא will find us זכאי בדין. Therefore, we should be saying שירה! So R' Yechezkel Levenstein asks in his שיחה, why therefore don't we say שירה on יום כיפור and ראש השנה?

He gives an interesting answer. What are the last three letters of the first three words in the torah? בְּרֵאשִׁית בָּרָא אֱלֹקִים. It's אמת. Yes, אמת, the letters are very far apart, but they are there right at the beginning of the torah. The חותם, the seal of הקדוש ברוך הוא is אמת. Therefore, it is our responsibility to be דבוק בהשם, to follow in Hashem's ways and והלכת בדרכיו, to also be אמת'דיק, to say the truth. Even if we have the אמונה that we will be found זכאי, and we're certain of that, we're confident of that, however, you can't have שמחה in that situation, because at the end of the day, it is a day of דין. It is a day of ספרי חיים וספרי מתים, which is exactly what הקדוש ברוך הוא told the מלאכים. That being the case, there is this element of fear, of the dread of אימת הדין. You have to have the proper השקפה and attitude and not think that this is just סתם אזוי, a happenstance. If we really understand what ראש השנה and יום כיפור are all about, we cannot possibly say שירה, because we still have to appreciate and have יראת שמים and יראת חטא. In the זכות of having both of those qualities, may we indeed be found זכאי בדין and have a גמר חתימה טובה. גוט געבענטשט געזונט יאר.

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